In the controversy, the emperor was overthrown and the Pope was kidnapped until he died amongst the Normans. During the early 12th century, European rulers were forced to accept the Popes as sole authorities who assigned high prelates. However, the rulers had the power to place sanctions upon the high prelates if they had enough evidence. With the turning of the 12th century, the Church had enough strength to demand a Crusade to take back the Holy Land.

When the Byzantine Empire was suffering from internal deterioration and decay, the Seljuk Turks were able to conquer the western forces in 1071 at Manzikert. As a result, the region known as Asia Minor became open to the Turkish forces. The Orthodox Church had broken away from the Catholic Church and was in danger. In 1096, the First Crusade was launched, which lasted for three years and resulted in the Christian forces taking back Jerusalem. A series of Crusader States were established under the feudal nobles. In 1147, the Second Crusade was launched but was unsuccessful. In 1197, the Holy Land was seized by Salah al-Din al-Ayyubi. From 1189 onwards, the Third Crusade began and ended after two years without any results. The Fourth Crusade began in 1202 and also lasted for two years. It too was a failure because of the infighting among the Frankish and Venetian leaders. Instead, they sacked Constantinople and founded states for the Byzantine king to return.

The disagreements with the Church had caused the German kings to become significantly weakened. It was only with the ascension of Frederick I Barbarossa in 1152 that the German monarchs began a revival during the Hohenstaufen dynasty. Frederick I Barbarossa managed to convince the feudal nobles to appoint him as their feudal overlord and was able to secure their allegiance for the most part. Frederick I Barbarossa initially travelled to Italy to help the Popes but found himself in the middle of Church succession disagreements. When he tried to make decisions, both the Church and the local towns reacted by fighting against him. They worked together to defeat him in 1176 at Legnano. In 1190, Frederick I Barbarossa died during the Third Crusade.